Constantine and Christianity

The Battle of the Milvian Bridge in 312 CE saw Constantine overpower Maxentius, which then allowed him to become the only emperor of both halves of the Roman Empire. He reigned between 306 and 337 CE and accredited his victory to Jesus Christ. He established the Edict of Milan in 317 CE and allowed people freedom of religious belief. Particularly, he increased tolerance towards the new religion, which would later become known as Christianity. Earlier Roman rulers had forged ties with a particular god or goddess to boost their authority and prestige. For example, Julius Caesar claimed he was descended from the goddess Venus on his father's side. Constantine chose Jesus Christ to cement his divine rights instead of choosing one of the roman deities.

In 325 CE at the First Council of Nicaea, Constantine oversaw the council to organize the religion and decide on critical theological issues such as the divinity of Christ. Texts were selected to be included in the official religious canon known as the Bible. The Roman Empire became stabilized again under Constantine's leadership and the economy grew once more. A new city known as New Rome was built at modern day Istanbul but it was later renamed as Constantinople. Christian writers refer to him as Constantine the Great because he was very devoted towards his faith. When he died, he was succeeded by his sons who quickly led the empire into a series of bloody wars. They undid all of the hard work their father had achieved during his rule.

Constantine II, Constantius II and Constans were the names of his three sons who separated the territory amongst themselves. After a few battles, Constantine II and Constans died, which left Constantius II to be emperor. He named his cousin Julian to succeed him. When he died, Julian took the throne but only lasted for two years between 361 and 363 CE. He attempted to bring back some of Rome's past glories through a series of reorganizations in the government. He forced the Christian officials from their posts, banned the faith, banned preaching of the scriptures and excluded all Christians from joining the army. Julian was the last pagan